PAW & FOUND



Cat Behavior Decoder

Understanding Your Feline Friend

Tail talks • Ear signals • Secret sounds • Why they do that weird thing

The friendly guide to finally understanding your cat

🐱 Why Cats Do What They Do

Cats aren't mysterious — they're just speaking a different language. Unlike dogs, who evolved to communicate with humans, cats retained much of their wild ancestor's body language. Every tail flick, ear turn, and slow blink is a message.

This guide helps you decode those signals. You'll learn what your cat is **really** saying — whether they're happy, stressed, playful, or telling you it's time for dinner (again).

The best part? Once you understand cat language, your relationship deepens. Your cat will trust you more because you're finally **listening**.

> 🐾 **QUICK TIP**
>
> Always look at the **whole cat** — ears + eyes + tail + body posture together. One signal alone can be misleading. Context is everything!

📏 Tail Positions Decoded

A cat's tail is like a mood ring. Here's what each position means:



Straight Up

Happy, confident, friendly. A tail held high with a slight curl at the tip = "I'm so glad to see you!"

Question Mark

Playful and curious. Your cat is in a great mood and ready to interact. Perfect time for play!



Swishing / Lashing

Agitation or excitement. Slow swish = focused (hunting mode). Fast lash = annoyed — back off!



Puffed Up

Frightened or startled. Cat is trying to look bigger. Give them space and remove the threat.



Tucked Under

Scared, nervous, or submissive. Your cat feels unsafe. Provide a quiet, secure spot.



Wrapped Around You

Affection! It's the cat equivalent of holding hands. They're marking you as theirs.

🐾 DID YOU KNOW?

Cats only meow at humans — not at other cats (except kittens to their mothers). Adult cats communicate with each other through scent, body language, and occasional hissing.

👂 Ear Positions & What They Mean

Cats have 32 muscles in each ear — they can rotate them 180 degrees. Ears are incredibly expressive!



Forward & Slightly Out

Relaxed and content. This is the neutral, happy resting position.



Straight Up & Forward

Alert and interested. They heard something and are assessing. May rotate toward the sound.



Sideways / Airplane Ears

Nervous, anxious, or annoyed. The more flattened, the more upset. Give space!



Fully Flattened Back

Frightened or defensive. Cat feels threatened and may lash out. Remove the stressor immediately.

⚠️ WARNING SIGN

Ears flat + dilated pupils + growling or hissing = **leave this cat alone right now**. This is fear-based aggression and they will scratch or bite.

📣 Common Vocalizations



Meow

All-purpose communication with humans. Short meow = greeting. Multiple meows = excited. Long, drawn-out meow = demand or complaint. The pitch and length tell you the urgency.



Purr

Usually contentment, but cats also purr when in pain or stressed — it's self-soothing. If your cat purrs at the vet, they're probably not happy — they're comforting themselves.



Chirp / Chatter

That rapid teeth-chattering sound when they see a bird? It's frustration + hunting instinct. Some experts think it mimics a killing bite. Totally normal!



Hiss

"Back off NOW." A warning, not aggression. Your cat is saying they're uncomfortable and need space. Respect the hiss — don't punish it. Remove the trigger.



Yowl / Howl

Distress, pain, or mating call. A long, loud, mournful sound. If your spayed/neutered cat is yowling, see a vet — it can indicate pain or cognitive issues in older cats.

🐾 Why Cats Knead, Head-Butt & Rub

🍞 Kneading (Making Biscuits)

This rhythmic paw-pushing goes back to kittenhood — kittens knead their mother's belly to stimulate milk flow. Adult cats knead when they feel **safe, content, and loved**. It's the ultimate compliment! They may also be marking you with scent glands in their paws.

🤕 Head-Butting (Bunting)

When your cat bonks their head against you, they're depositing pheromones from glands on their forehead. It means **"you're part of my colony."** It's a sign of trust, affection, and belonging. Head-butt them back gently — they love it.

🦵 Rubbing Against Your Legs

Same idea — scent marking. Your cat is claiming you as theirs. They're also picking up your scent, blending the colony smell. It's both affection and a feline "welcome home."

🤷 Why Cats Knock Things Over

🪨 The Classic Paw-Swipe

It's not spite — it's instinct! Cats use their paws to explore objects the way we use our hands. They're testing: *Is this prey? Does it move? What happens if I push it?* If it falls and makes a satisfying noise, that's even more interesting.

💡 Why They Do It

- **Hunting instinct:** Batting at things is how cats test if something is alive
- **Attention-seeking:** If knocking something over gets you to look up from your phone, they learn fast
- **Boredom:** An under-stimulated cat will make their own fun
- **Curiosity:** Cats are scientists — they run experiments

🛑 How to Reduce It

Provide puzzle toys, regular play sessions, and vertical space (cat trees). Secure valuable items. Never punish — they won't connect the punishment to the action.

😌 The Slow Blink & Night Zoomies

😌 The Slow Blink — "I Love You" in Cat

When your cat looks at you and slowly closes and opens their eyes, they're saying **"I trust you completely."** In the wild, closing your eyes is vulnerable. A cat that slow-blinks at you feels totally safe.

Try it: Get on their level, relax your face, and slowly blink back. Hold your eyes closed for a second. Many cats will return the blink — it's a conversation!

🏃 Night Zoomies Explained

That 3 AM sprint around the house? **Cats are crepuscular** — naturally most active at dawn and dusk. Indoor cats build up energy all day, then release it in bursts. It's totally normal!

To reduce zoomies: Play with your cat for 15–20 minutes before bed. Use a wand toy to simulate hunting. A tired cat is a quiet cat.

🚽 Litter Box Body Language

✅ Normal Litter Box Behavior

A healthy cat uses the box quietly and covers their waste. Urinating 2–4 times a day and defecating once daily is typical. Some cats are private; others want an audience — both are fine.

🚨 Red Flags (Call the Vet)

- **Straining or crying** in the box — possible urinary blockage (emergency!)
- **Going outside the box** suddenly — not spite; likely medical or stress-related
- **Blood in urine** — UTI, crystals, or other issues
- **Frequent trips with little output** — urinary tract issue
- **Scooting or excessive licking** — may indicate anal gland issues or parasites

🏠 Litter Box Rules

Rule: **one box per cat, plus one extra.** Place in quiet, accessible spots — not next to loud appliances. Scoop daily. Use unscented litter (cats hate strong fragrances).

📋 Quick Reference Cheatsheet



Happy & Relaxed

Tail up, slow blinks, purring, kneading, ears forward. Cat feels safe and loved.



Playful

Tail up with curl, chirping, dilated pupils, pouncing stance. Time to play!



Annoyed

Tail swishing fast, ears sideways, low growl. Give them space immediately.



Frightened

Puffed tail, flattened ears, crouched body, hissing. Remove the threat, provide a hiding spot.



In Pain / Distress

Hiding, yowling, not eating, litter box issues. See a vet — cats hide pain well.



I Love You

Slow blinks, head-butting, kneading you, following you around, showing their belly (but don't always touch!).



Hungry / Demanding

Insistent meowing, leading you to the bowl, pawing at you. They trained you well.



Sleepy / Cozy

Curled up, slow blinks, purring softly. Cats sleep 12–16 hours a day — it's normal!

🐾 **The secret to a happy cat? Listen to what they're telling you. They've been talking all along.**